



Here Emperor Julian is seen in religious debate. He attempted to sow discord among Christians by decreeing the return of those who had been exiled for religious reasons.

IN CHINA, THE EASTERN JIN DYNASTY (317–420) brought comparative stability to the south of the country. Although many of the emperors were short-lived, the bureaucracy in the southern capital of Nanjing functioned efficiently and the period saw a **cultural flowering**. Artists such as Gu Kaizhi (c. 345–406) painted masterpieces such as the *Admonitions of the Instructress to the Palace Ladies*, as well as producing works on the theory of painting. **Northern China**, on the other hand, was **highly unstable**, divided between the Sixteen Kingdoms, most of them ruled by **nomadic groups**. The Eastern Jin emperors alternated between a defensive stance towards the Sixteen Kingdoms and aggressive campaigns, notably under Mudi (r. 345–61) who retook Sichuan and Luoyang. All these gains were lost, however, under Emperor Aidì (r. 362–65). In 383, the Eastern Jin

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THE NUMBER OF KINGDOMS IN CHINA FROM 304 TO 439

(under Xiaowudi) would be forced to repel a major invasion in the north of the country.

In the Roman Empire, **Julian** was proclaimed **Augustus** by his troops in 360, so he was a direct challenge to Constantius. The threat from the Persians, who were advancing through Asia Minor, was too great for

Constantius to meet immediately. **He died** in November 361 as he was finally marching west to deal with the revolt. Now sole emperor, Julian immediately set about **restoring the role of paganism** in the Roman Empire, trying to establish a kind of pagan orthodoxy and an official pagan hierarchy of priests to counter Christianity's strengths. He reopened pagan temples, and

restored the right to sacrifice.

In 363, Julian set out on a **campaign against Persia**, planning to punish its leader, Shapur II, for his attacks on the empire in 359–60. He reached Ctesiphon, but was then forced to retreat up the Tigris River. Being short of supplies, the Roman army suffered constant harassment from the Persians and, in one such skirmish, **Julian was killed**. The pagan reaction was over.

On Julian's death the army chose **Jovian** (r. 363–64) as emperor,

but he ceded key border provinces to Persia, which lost him popularity, and he died (probably murdered) within months. An officer of the imperial bodyguard, **Valentinian** (r. 364–75), was then raised to the throne, and he selected his brother **Valens** (r. 364–78) to be his **co-ruler**. Valentinian spent much of his reign along the Rhine dealing with Frankish and Alemannic invaders. He died in 375 after suffering some type of seizure, brought on by his anger at

barbarian Quadi envoys thought to have insulted him.

The Western Roman Empire was then

subdivided between Valentinian's two sons **Gratian** (r. 375–83) and **Valentinian II** (r. 375–92). In the Eastern Empire, Valens was forced to spend most of the early 370s in Syria to contain the Persian threat, but growing trouble with barbarians along the Danube later forced him to turn to the Balkans.

Sarmatian dagger

This dagger belonged to the Sarmatians, a tribe of Iranian origin who specialized in horseback fighting, and were defeated by Valentinian I.



The church of Hagia Eirene in Istanbul was built by Constantine I.

“... THE BARBARIANS, [ARE] LIKE BEASTS ... **BROKEN LOOSE... OVER THE VAST EXTENT... OF COUNTRY.**”

Ammianus Marcellinus, on the Gothic invasion of the Balkans c. 390

IN 376, LARGE GROUPS OF GOTH ARRIVED AT THE DANUBE FRONTIER, pressing to be admitted to the Roman Empire. **The Huns**, a new nomadic group from Central Asia, were at their rear, and the Goths feared being squeezed between them and the imperial frontier. Emperor Valens did not wait for reinforcements before marching out to meet the Gothic army. On August 9, 378, near Adrianople, **the Romans met the Goths**, under Fritigern. Misled by the temporary absence of the Gothic cavalry, Valens attacked but his army was surrounded by the returning barbarian horsemen. Valens was killed and the **Eastern army destroyed**, leaving the Balkans open to the Goths.

Gratian reacted by turning to **Theodosius**, a Spanish military officer, who he appointed as his imperial colleague. For the next three years Theodosius patiently negotiated, bought off some groups, and struck militarily where he could. In 382, the two

JULIAN THE APOSTATE (331–63)

The nephew of Constantine I, Julian was educated as a Christian but c. 351 became a pagan under the influence of Maximus of Ephesus. When Julian unexpectedly became emperor in 363, he tried to restore paganism in the empire, including banning Christians from teaching literature. He became known by Christian writers as “the Apostate” for his perceived betrayal of Christianity.

